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Multimodal Literacy Narrative: My Growth in Literacy

My literacy journey began, like anyone else as soon as I was born and began interpreting the world around me for the first time. From my first words to the present day, my literacy has been and will continue to evolve and shape the way I think. My parents, naturally, were my first literary sponsors as they assisted my growth into the person I am today. Deborah Brandt, an English professor at the University of Wisconsin, defines a sponsor as someone who lends “their resources or credibility to the sponsored but also stand to gain benefits from their success” (Brandt, p. 167). While they may not directly benefit from my success, my parents are sponsors in that they gain fulfillment from seeing me succeed as a person. My writing identity has developed through the combined influence of this early parental guidance, along with extracurricular involvement, media exposure, and experiences within the school system. These experiences in literacy and personal communication have enabled me to pursue further education and have given me the drive to have a fulfilling professional career down the line.

My parents began reading to me when I was incredibly young and I largely attribute my proficiency in reading and writing to this as I found success early on. Shown right is me with my first book, which was simple of course, but began exposing me to literature. I found that



reading when I was young allowed me to quickly develop better vocabulary and reading comprehension skills. But further than just developing my vocabulary and reading ability, my parents also helped to shape my values and built the foundation to communicate effectively. They taught me to speak to others with respect and act well mannered. This transferred to being able to effectively communicate with teachers, employers, and professors professionally. But their influence was immediate as I had an above average reading level through the entirety of grade school as they pushed me to vigorously pursue my education. This eventually led me to placement in the gifted program at my school. This program allowed me to build writing skills early on as they introduced us to critical thinking skills such as research and problem solving.

This allowed me to attend the gifted creativity Olympics in 3rd grade, earning first place in the competition (shown right). This competition helped me to further develop interpersonal literacy as I



had to exhibit teamwork to succeed in the competition, which involved a series of problem-

solving tasks. These skills hold immense value in literacy as they are necessary to collaboration and the understanding of others.

After elementary school, I went to a full-time gifted program at Dunedin Middle School where I saw immense growth in literacy through my education. One of my most valuable literacy experiences was my 6th grade ELA course, in which I achieved a perfect score on the final



writing assessment. This course was so valuable because my teacher had us learn 500 word stems, allowing us to decipher the meaning of words we might not have seen before. This continued through the entire year before we had our medieval-themed word stem 500 test at the end of the year, which ran very similarly to a spelling bee, but with stems and their definitions (shown left). This was a crucial skill moving forward when completing any kind of text analysis for

research papers and standardized testing, specifically the SAT. Furthermore, it helped me develop a wider vocabulary that increased my effectiveness as a communicator. Another class that I attribute my literacy growth towards is AP Research, which I took in my junior year of high school. This class exposed me to the difference between literature review and true research. I was required to complete a diverse literary analysis of over 40 sources before conducting my own research on the impact of light on attention. Overall, this class substantially progressed my writing ability as well as my ability to gather sources and conduct experimental research.

Outside of school, I also participated in a wide range of extracurricular activities that allowed me to develop tight knit relationships and become a better communicator in a variety of situations. One of my first interests began in music class in elementary school, as I loved to play

the xylophone. I went on to begin taking xylophone and drum lessons outside of school in order to pursue this passion. However, this was ultimately overtaken by my ultimate passion growing up: hockey. Outside of parental and educational influences, I would argue that my experiences playing hockey have had the largest influence on my way of thinking. I began playing when I was 10 years old and through the sport, I was able to meet lifelong friends and develop skills that have transferred to all other aspects of my life. Shown to the right is my senior class for the High School Hockey team, who were also



some of my best friends. Hockey pushed me to effectively communicate with adults, in the form of coaches or parents, and instilled values such as respect. However, communicating with my peers in hockey was often different from how I communicated with adults and other people of importance. I found that hockey allowed me to develop literacy skills on multiple ends of the spectrum. Professor Vershawn Ashanti Young discusses a similar idea in their essay “‘Nah, We Straight’: An Argument Against Code Switching” which discusses the idea of switching between different dialects depending on the situation. The essay discusses how “students transition from home grammar to school grammar in the classroom” and highlights the differences in dialects when speaking with diverse groups of people (Young, p.50). The context of the essay was the differences between how children generally spoke in a black household versus how they were expected to speak at school. I found a connection between this idea and hockey as I found myself speaking differently, even depending on the presence/absence of a coach.

This feeling of speaking and acting as a slightly different version of myself depending on the group of people I was interacting with continued to be prevalent in all facets of my life. I found that being able to communicate in a variety of different atmospheres effectively was a crucial skill in having success across multiple aspects of my life. Influences such as parents, coaches, and teachers taught me how to speak professionally, while peers such as my teammates and classmates strengthened my ability to interact with other people my age. This further developed as I began taking on acts of community service in high school. One



of the most impactful on my literacy was joining the Best Buddies program where I spent time with the special needs students at my high school (shown right). This experience allowed me to develop qualities such as compassion and patience as I interacted with those who were differently abled than myself. Moreover, I also got to meet many of the buddies' parents which greatly impacted my worldview as I was able to see a small part of how they lived their lives. Communication skills such as body language and tone developed through Best Buddies as I communicated with those who process information differently. My overall experience with Best Buddies allowed me to learn to communicate with those who are different than myself and allowed me to further develop relationships with my peers through involvement. Along with the Best Buddies program, I was also a summer camp counselor throughout high school at outdoor camps such as fishing, kayaking, and paddleboarding. This experience allowed me to learn how to effectively communicate with parents in a way that exhibits trust and how to teach skills to younger children.

Once I was coming towards the end of my high school experience, I also took on a job at Publix where I developed more communication skills while working in customer service. This job was my first truly professional environment and helped me develop the skills necessary to communicate with my superiors properly and respectfully, while also learning how to interact with customers. Shown right is me meeting Mr. Olympia winner Dereck Lunsford while he was shopping at the store. Much of the job was spent on the sales floor, where I was able to interact with customers and assist them with their needs. This taught me to “read” conversations and audiences to best assist the customer. This involved taking note of urgency, facial expressions, and conversational cues. This job also developed my professional literacy as I was expected to learn professional tone and concise writing. This ties back to the idea of code switching as I learned to communicate in a workplace environment.



Now that I am in college, I would say that the pinnacle of my current literary ability was my college acceptance essay, where I talked about a personal event and how that helped build the person I am today. I believe that my experiences, both in and outside of school, have helped to prepare me for this class, similarly to how this class will prepare me for what lies ahead. This is supported by UCF Assistant Professor Kara Taczak who claims that “transfer is so important in first year writing because it’s attempting to teach you to be a more effective writer for your future” (Taczak, p.303). Overall, I believe that the idea of literacy is incredibly vast, containing

ideas such as writing, verbal communication, and even how you think. Literacy drives society and improving one's literacy is the best way to prepare themselves for their future.

Works Cited

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